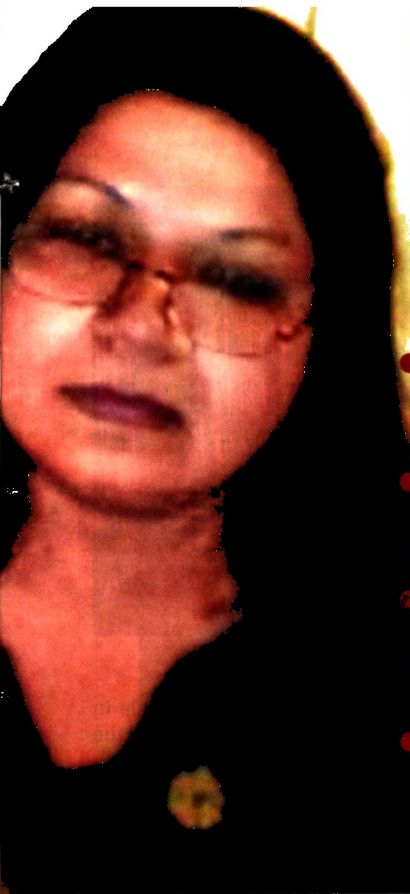


INDIAN undercover operatives in Pakistan whose identities have been compromised may have to be shifted.

BUGS may have been planted in the Indian mission and vital intelligence compromised on India's Afghanistan strategy.

THE ROLES of an official in the Intelligence Bureau earlier posted in Pakistan and that of a senior Army official are being probed.

A KASHMIR connection which unearthed the spy ring has also surfaced, revealing Gupta's links to a Rajouri agent who was being watched by intelligence agencies.

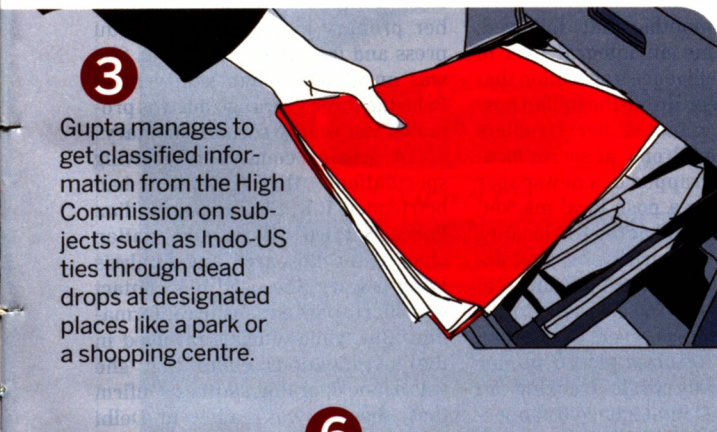
GUPTA provided her handlers with insights on the Indo-US intelligence cooperation and on India's thinking on the composite dialogue process as well as its Afghanistan strategy.

| By Saurabh Shukla |

She is being called India's Mata Hari, the first woman officer to be arrested for spying for a hostile country. When Madhuri Gupta, 53, second secretary at the Indian High Commission in Islamabad, received a message from the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) in Delhi that she had been assigned temporary duty in Thimpu for the SAARC summit, she confidently told her handlers in Pakistan that she will be bringing back a treasure trove of information. She was still unaware that she was under surveillance by Indian intelligence agencies and her trip to Delhi was orchestrated to arrest her when she landed last week. To ensure secrecy, only a handful of people in the security establishment and the MEA were kept in the loop, and to make it look like a routine assignment, another second secretary from the commercial section was asked to accompany her. A day after she landed, she was taken into custody, ending a surveillance operation that had been going on for the past eight months. Her first reaction when told she was being arrested for espionage was: "Why did you take so long?"

A bespectacled spinster, Gupta is no glamorous spy but clearly a clever one: she passed on sensitive information to Pakistan intelligence without detection for more than two years. "It came as a shock for us, she was sophisticated and spoke polished English, but is a bit temperamental," remarked a senior colleague. A junior diplomat in the Indian mission, Gupta was arrested for breaching the Official Secrets Act; she now faces up to ten years in prison and dismissal from service. "The reason she was called back to Delhi indicates that charges against her were serious," remarked External Affairs Minister S.M. Krishna.

What is known so far is Gupta's modus operandi: her liaisons began on a chilly morning in Islamabad in December 2007 when she met a leading Pakistani Urdu journalist, who is believed to be on the mission's radar as a suspected intelligence operative. She was told to look for information from him, instead he found Gupta more vulnerable and bearing a grudge against her seniors for "treating her like dirt", and saw her as an ideal recruit. Over several meetings, the journalist identified as Jafar, introduced her to a few of his friends. In early 2008, she met



3 Gupta manages to get classified information from the High Commission on subjects such as Indo-US ties through dead drops at designated places like a park or a shopping centre.



6 She is called to Delhi for temporary duty and whisked away from the airport by intelligence officials. She is accused of spying and arrested by the police a day later.